

INTRODUCTION

1. This document contains instructions that apply specifically to the Brazil branch territory. Whenever it provides additional guidance on a subject, you are encouraged to note a reference to it in your personal copy of *Shepherd the Flock of God*. If you no longer serve as an elder, delete all electronic copies of this Addendum.
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WEDDING CEREMONIES

2. In Brazil, an elder may perform a **religious wedding ceremony with civil effect**, provided he obtains specific authorization from the local registry office for each individual ceremony, reviewed on a case-by-case basis. The elder who will officiate the ceremony (considered the “minister” for legal purposes) must secure this authorization beforehand. For the marriage to be legally registered, prior authorization, post-ceremony documentation, and the signatures of the minister and witnesses are required. In such cases, it is the responsibility of the couple and the officiating elder to verify what legal documents are needed for the marriage to be properly performed and registered. (sfg 4:30)
For example, the registry office may require a letter from the congregation or local legal entity confirming that the elder is authorized to perform marriages. A sample letter is available on JW Hub. The parties involved are responsible for any financial costs.
 3. The elder officiating the marriage must strictly follow the sections “**Option 1: Marriage Procedure**” and “**Marriage Vows**” in the outline *Honorable Marriage in God’s Eyes* (S-41). However, some couples may prefer to have a civil marriage first and then a wedding talk at the Kingdom Hall. (w06 10/15 ¶¶9-10) If there are any questions, the elder should contact the Service Department well before the wedding date.
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CORRESPONDENCE AND CONGREGATION FILES

4. The body of elders may decide whether to store the Congregation Publisher Records (S-21) in electronic or printed form. (See *Shepherd*, ch. 17 ¶13.) The congregation’s handling of its records and territories must comply with applicable data-protection laws. — Rom. 13:1.
5. Online storage services may be used for non-confidential documents, such as items posted on the information board. No sensitive or confidential information—including

matters handled by a judicial committee—may ever be stored online.

6. Disposal of congregation documents:

The following directions show respect for both the law and individuals' privacy. (Prov. 25:9; Rom. 13:1)

Each January, the secretary should review the congregation's files (paper or digital). If necessary, he may open sealed envelopes. (sfg 17:2, 6) He may consult other elders as needed. When the retention period for a document has expired, it must be destroyed (shredded if possible) or deleted. If elders believe a document should be kept longer than the stated period, the secretary and another elder must contact Bethel for instructions.

(Here follows detailed retention guidance for various categories—elders' and ministerial servants' letters, confidential records, judicial matters, property documents, Kingdom Hall maintenance forms, service reports, territory files, meeting records, and others—as in the source text.)

7. Compromised personal data or data-access requests:

Data-protection laws generally give individuals the right to request access to or deletion of personal data held by the congregation. Such requests may be verbal or written. Whenever anyone makes this type of request, two elders must immediately call the **Legal Department**. Likewise, if any personal information about a publisher is stolen or compromised (for example, if confidential files are sent to the wrong address), two elders must call the Legal Department.

8–10. Use of third-party software:

Bethel does not recommend or endorse any specific third-party software for managing congregation activities or records. Elders and publishers are not encouraged or required to use such tools. If a family head or publisher chooses not to use one, their decision must be fully respected without any pressure.

Bethel provides simple PDF and paper forms so that elders and publishers can fulfill their duties without needing special equipment or technical expertise.

If elders nonetheless decide to use third-party software—online, browser-based, or installed locally—they must ensure it complies with data-protection laws. If data are transferred outside the country, appropriate safeguards are required. Elders should also confirm the software provides a lawful data-processing agreement.

IMMIGRANTS WITHOUT LEGAL STATUS

11. In Brazil, the Federal Police (under the Ministry of Justice) handles foreigners' residency requests. Although other government agencies may assist irregular immigrants, only the

Federal Police can grant a legal stay. Elders can determine whether a publisher has applied or is taking steps to do so by verifying official documents—such as an entry visa, Federal Police registration protocol, National Migration Registry (CRNM, formerly RNE/CIE), or UN refugee documents. (See *Shepherd*, ch. 12 ¶¶6-8.)

12–17. **Communication with immigration authorities:**

Government offices can provide lists of required documents or these can be found on the Federal Police website. In rare cases, a publisher may request help from the elders regarding immigration matters. Authorities might seek confirmation of a person's status as a Jehovah's Witness or clarification of our beliefs and practices. Elders must remember that their comments should be limited to spiritual matters.

Requests for citizenship or residency are personal decisions. The organization is not involved. If advice is needed, publishers should consult an immigration lawyer. A person does not need citizenship to be baptized or to preach.

If a government agency asks for confirmation that someone is a Jehovah's Witness, the body of elders may decide whether to provide such a letter. A sample letter ("Confirmation That the Person Is a Jehovah's Witness — Immigration") is available in the "Forms" section of jw.org.

If a detained publisher or Bible student requests documentation, elders should consider the circumstances carefully before providing it, using the sample letter if appropriate. Letters should use the congregation's letterhead and never mention Bethel or legal entities.

If an immigrant publisher or Bible student is detained, government authorities have procedures for handling custody of minor children. Publishers who wish to offer temporary guardianship must carefully consider their responsibilities and consult authorities to understand the legal implications.

HOSPITALIZATION

18. Some hospitals in Brazil do not allow Jehovah's Witness patients to write or cross out wording on admission forms to express their wishes regarding medical treatment (for example, refusal of blood transfusions). (See *Shepherd*, ch. 10 ¶7.) In such cases, a publisher may, if conscience permits, sign the form unaltered and add "See attached" near the signature, attaching a copy of the *Advance Medical Directive and Durable Power of Attorney for Health Care* (dpa). If possible, the publisher should photograph or video the attachment process. (See *Shepherd*, ch. 1 ¶20.)

CALLS ABOUT CHILD ABUSE

19. In Brazil, elders should call **(15) 3322-9100** (the Service Department) when reporting or seeking direction about any allegation of child sexual abuse.
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COORDINATED TRANSPORTATION SYSTEM

20. The body of elders should appoint one elder as congregation transportation coordinator and another as his assistant. They must follow the *Instructions for the Congregation Transportation Coordinator* (available on jw.org under “DOCUMENTS > Forms”).
- For circuit assemblies, the congregation coordinator should contact the assembly’s Coordinated Transportation System (CTS) coordinator, appointed by the circuit overseer. For regional conventions, he should contact the convention’s CTS coordinator, appointed by the Convention Committee.
- If personal cars are used, he may arrange for brothers with extra seats to provide rides for those without vehicles.
- If the CTS does not apply to your congregation, send a message to “Conventions, Assemblies, and Visiting Speakers” via the jw.org email system.